

MAMMA MIA! UK & INTERNATIONAL TOUR 2023 CAST. PHOTOGRAPHY BY BRINKHOFF/MÖGENBURG. © LITTLESTAR

with a company of 56 people, comprising cast, musicians, and technical crew. During the load into each new venue, we have an additional 10 highly experienced crew coming from the UK to help our company assemble and construct the set, lighting, and sound in the short space of time we have before the opening night. The same people return at the end of the season to help us take it all out again!"

Grace confesses he has been trying to get *MAMMA MIA!* to India for over 19 years. "I was waiting for a suitable theatre in India for our production and my discussions with the NMACC started over three years ago, so I am absolutely delighted to have now opened it here, one of the best and most beautiful theatres in the world." ■

Priya Pathiyan



MUSIC

Good Old Rock 'N' Roll

One of the world's greatest contemporary rock bands, The War on Drugs, will perform at Bandland in Bengaluru this month

When they perform at the Bandland festival in Bengaluru this month, American rock band The War On Drugs will be for many attendees what in music industry parlance is called a 'discovery act'. The group, helmed by singer, guitarist and composer Adam Granduciel, may not be as well known to Indian audiences as the headliners Deep Purple and the Goo Goo Dolls, but they're widely regarded as one of the world's biggest rock bands and have played several of its top festivals.

Their show at Bandland on December 16 will cap a year that included spots at Glastonbury in the UK, Primavera Sound in Spain and Summerfest in the US. Granduciel's nostalgia-evoking compositions, swathed in layers of guitar and synthesiser, and his evocative lyrics, introspective yet abstract enough to allow multiple interpretations, have made them a group that can connect with big crowds.

They're also the kind of act whose music is reminiscent of a specific set of legendary artists. A shorthand description of The War On Drugs could be Tom Petty crooning a Bruce Springsteen composition co-written by Bob Dylan. In an exclusive interview with INDIA TODAY, Granduciel said he chooses to embrace rather than be annoyed by the constant references. "It would be silly to say that people we get compared to aren't huge influences on us," he says. "I welcome it because it's the bridge that opens the thing we do only the way we can do it, to a wider audience."

For listeners in India, it's this very characteristic that makes them the perfect link between veteran classic rock ensembles such as Parikrama and newer alternative rock outfits like The F16s, believes BookMyShow, the promoter and producer of Bandland. A sense of cinematic vastness, closely associated with being on the move, is another distinguishing feature of The War On Drugs' sound. It's why they're on Spotify playlists named 'Indie Roadtrip', 'Indie x Running' and 'My Life is a Movie'. "They're my go-to driving music," says Owen Roncon, the chief of business at the live entertainment division at BookMyShow.

The band's nostalgia-evoking compositions and evocative lyrics have made them a group that can easily connect with big crowds

Granduciel, who says they'll play the best-known tracks from their last three records—2014's breakthrough release *Lost in the Dream*, 2017's Best Rock Album Grammy-winner *A Deeper Understanding* and 2021's critically lauded *I Don't Live Here Anymore*—at Bandland, dismisses claims that rock, which isn't as commercially successful as it used to be, is an endangered genre. "People have been saying that for a long time, for [like] 25 years. All my favourite new acts are rock bands with female singers and guitar players." What has changed, he agrees, is that "people are digesting all sorts of music; they'll listen to The War On Drugs, Beyonce and an EDM DJ". ■

Amit Gurbaxani